

VIETNAM

14-Day Relaxed Journey

Hanoi - Ninh Binh - Pu Luong - Hoi An - Da Nang

A slow-travel itinerary built around local food, boating, nature, beaches and quieter moments.

STYLE	Relaxed & flexible	FOOD	Pho + banh mi
PACE	1-2 key activities/day	BOATING	Trang An
BEST FOR	Summer vacation	BUDGET	AUD 1,200-1,750*

Trip philosophy. This plan deliberately avoids a checklist-style holiday. Popular sights are visited early, the hottest hours are kept light, and several afternoons are left open for cafes, pools, beaches or simply resting. The aim is to make crowds an inconvenience - not something that ruins the trip.

Days 1-3	HANOI	Street food, pho, banh mi, cafes & culture
Days 4-5	NINH BINH	Rice fields, cycling & Trang An boat journey
Days 6-7	PU LUONG	Terraces, villages, mountain resort & slow countryside
Days 8-11	HOI AN	Ancient Town, cooking, banh mi & An Bang Beach
Days 12-14	DA NANG	My Khe Beach, Marble Mountains & seafood

*Planning estimate for one traveller in comfortable private rooms. International flights and shopping are excluded. Two travellers sharing a room can reduce the per-person accommodation cost considerably.

Before You Go

WHEN TO SIGHTSEE	08:00-11:30 and after 16:00. Keep 13:00-16:00 for lunch, hotel, pool, spa or cafes.
CROWD STRATEGY	Prioritise weekdays, arrive early at famous attractions, avoid large bus tours, and stay just outside nightlife-heavy areas.
TRANSPORT	Use Grab in cities, limousine vans for Hanoi-Ninh Binh, arranged transfers for Pu Luong, and a domestic flight from Hanoi to Ha Long Bay.
FOOD APPROACH	Mix famous local specialities with small neighbourhood eateries. For street food, choose busy stalls with high turnover.
PACKING	Light breathable clothing, sun protection, insect repellent, comfortable walking shoes, a light rain layer, and a small first aid kit.

DAY 1 | ARRIVE IN HANOI

Easy arrival & first taste of Vietnam

TIME	PLAN
15:00-17:00	Check in, shower and rest. Do not schedule a major attraction after a long flight.
17:30-18:30	Walk around Hoan Kiem Lake and get oriented in the Old Quarter.
19:00-20:15	First Vietnamese dinner: keep it simple with pho, bun cha or a rice dish.
20:15-21:00	Coffee or a short evening walk, then return to the hotel.
STAY	Stay: Hoan Kiem / Old Quarter, on a quieter side street rather than the bar-heavy core. Target AUD 45-70/night.
FOOD / EXPERIENCE	Food target: pho or bun cha; Vietnamese iced coffee.
BUDGET	Estimated day spend: AUD 70-105.

DAY 2 | HANOI

Pho, Old Quarter & cafe culture

TIME	PLAN
08:00	Breakfast: pho bo (beef) or pho ga (chicken).
09:00-11:15	Walk Hoan Kiem - St Joseph's Cathedral - quieter Old Quarter lanes. Browse slowly rather than chasing every landmark.
11:30-12:45	Lunch. Try bun cha or banh cuon.
13:00-15:30	Hotel rest. This protects you from the strongest summer heat.
15:45-17:15	Cafe time. Try egg coffee or coconut coffee.
18:00-19:15	Local dinner.
19:30-20:45	Optional Old Quarter evening walk. Leave when crowds stop being enjoyable.
STAY	Stay: same Hanoi hotel.
FOOD / EXPERIENCE	Food target: pho, bun cha, banh cuon, egg coffee.
BUDGET	Estimated day spend: AUD 55-90 plus accommodation.

DAY 3 | HANOI

Banh mi & a light cultural day

TIME	PLAN
08:00	Breakfast: banh mi.
09:30-11:15	Temple of Literature and surrounding streets.

TIME	PLAN
11:45-13:00	Lunch.
13:15-15:45	Return to hotel for rest / pool / cafe.
16:15-18:00	West Lake area for a slower neighbourhood atmosphere.
19:00-20:30	Dinner and an unhurried final evening in Hanoi.
STAY	Stay: same Hanoi hotel.
FOOD / EXPERIENCE	Food target: banh mi; try a different pho style if you want a second comparison.
BUDGET	Estimated day spend: AUD 55-90 plus accommodation.

DAY 4 | HANOI -> NINH BINH

Rice fields & cycling

TIME	PLAN
08:00	Breakfast and check-out.
09:00-11:30	Limousine van to Tam Coc / Ninh Binh. Approx. AUD 13-21.
12:00-14:15	Check in, lunch and settle in.
15:00-17:30	Rent a bicycle and ride quiet roads around Tam Coc rice fields and villages.
18:30-20:00	Dinner near the hotel; early night before Trang An.
STAY	Stay: Tam Coc rather than Ninh Binh city. Look for a boutique hotel or small resort with garden/pool. Target AUD 45-75/night.
FOOD / EXPERIENCE	Food target: local goat dishes if interested, rice dishes, fresh vegetables and simple Vietnamese home-style food.
BUDGET	Estimated day spend: AUD 80-110.

DAY 5 | NINH BINH

Trang An - signature boating experience

TIME	PLAN
07:00	Wake up.
07:30	Breakfast.
08:00	Leave for Trang An before large tour groups build up.
08:30-11:30	Trang An boat journey: limestone peaks, caves, river passages and temple stops. Allow around three hours.
12:00-13:15	Lunch.
13:30-16:45	Hotel pool, nap or quiet reading. No second major attraction is necessary.
17:15-18:30	Optional sunset bicycle ride.
19:00	Dinner.
STAY	Stay: same Tam Coc hotel.
FOOD / EXPERIENCE	Experience budget: allow roughly AUD 16 for Trang An entry/boat, plus transport to the pier.
BUDGET	Estimated day spend: AUD 75-105.

DAY 6 | NINH BINH -> PU LUONG

Move into the mountains

TIME	PLAN
08:00	Breakfast and a slow morning.
09:30-13:00	Transfer to Pu Luong.
13:00-14:30	Check in and lunch.
15:00-18:00	Unscheduled resort time: pool, terrace views, coffee and sunset.
19:00	Dinner at the accommodation.
STAY	Stay: eco-resort or comfortable homestay with terrace/mountain views. Target AUD 60-100/night.
FOOD / EXPERIENCE	Food target: sticky rice, mountain vegetables, grilled chicken/pork and local home-style dishes.
BUDGET	Estimated day spend: AUD 90-120.

DAY 7 | PU LUONG

The slowest day of the trip

TIME	PLAN
08:00	Breakfast.
09:00-11:30	Easy countryside walk through villages, terraces and water-wheel areas. Avoid a long hardcore trek.
12:00	Lunch.
13:00-16:30	Pool, nap and free time.
17:00-18:30	Short sunset walk.
19:00	Local dinner.
STAY	Stay: same Pu Luong accommodation.
FOOD / EXPERIENCE	Why this day matters: it gives you a real break from major tourist centres and keeps the trip from feeling rushed.
BUDGET	Estimated day spend: AUD 90-115.

DAY 8 | PU LUONG -> HANOI -> HOI AN

Transport day - intentionally light

TIME	PLAN
07:30	Breakfast.
08:30-12:30	Transfer back toward Hanoi.
Afternoon	Continue to Hanoi airport with comfortable buffer time.
16:00-18:00 target	Fly Hanoi to Da Nang; flight time is roughly 1 hr 20 min.
Evening	Transfer 45-60 minutes to Hoi An, check in, eat something simple and sleep.
STAY	Stay: Hoi An Ancient Town fringe or Cam Chau. Avoid the loudest night-market streets. Target AUD 55-80/night.
FOOD / EXPERIENCE	Transport target: domestic flight roughly AUD 50-100+ depending on date, baggage and booking time.
BUDGET	No sightseeing target today - protecting energy is part of the itinerary.

DAY 9 | HOI AN

Ancient Town, lanterns & banh mi

TIME	PLAN
08:30	Slow breakfast.

TIME	PLAN
09:30-11:30	Explore Hoi An Ancient Town before the evening crowds.
12:00-13:00	Lunch: cao lau, white rose dumplings or banh mi.
13:15-16:15	Hotel rest / pool.
16:45-18:00	Return to the Ancient Town as the light softens.
18:00-19:00	Dinner.
19:00-20:30	Enjoy the lantern atmosphere, riverfront and evening streets.
20:30	Leave when the centre becomes too crowded.
STAY	Stay: same Hoi An hotel.
FOOD / EXPERIENCE	Food target: banh mi, cao lau, white rose dumplings, Hoi An chicken rice.
BUDGET	Estimated day spend: AUD 80-115.

DAY 10 | HOI AN

Cooking experience & An Bang Beach

TIME	PLAN
08:00	Breakfast.
09:00-12:30	Small-group Vietnamese cooking class, ideally with a local market component.
13:00-15:30	Hotel rest.
16:00-18:30	An Bang Beach: swim, read, relax and have a drink.
19:00	Beachside dinner.
21:00	Return to hotel.
STAY	Stay: same Hoi An hotel.
FOOD / EXPERIENCE	Cooking class budget: approximately AUD 30-50.
BUDGET	Estimated day spend: AUD 100-140.

DAY 11 | HOI AN

Full free day

TIME	PLAN
09:00 onward	Sleep in. Start with banh mi, coffee or brunch.
Late morning	Optional massage, tailor visit, shopping or cafe hopping.
Afternoon	Choose between hotel pool and An Bang Beach.
Evening	Return to your favourite restaurant or explore a quieter neighbourhood.
STAY	Stay: same Hoi An hotel.
FOOD / EXPERIENCE	This day is intentionally unscheduled. If you loved the Ancient Town, revisit it. If the crowds annoyed you, spend the entire day elsewhere.
BUDGET	Estimated day spend: AUD 55-100 plus accommodation.

DAY 12 | HOI AN -> DA NANG

Beach-city transition

TIME	PLAN
09:00	Breakfast.
10:30	Check out.
11:00-12:00	Transfer to Da Nang.
12:30	Lunch.
14:00-16:30	Hotel rest.
17:00-19:00	My Khe Beach: swimming and a long beach walk.
19:30	Seafood dinner.
STAY	Stay: My Khe Beach area. Target AUD 55-85/night.
FOOD / EXPERIENCE	Food target: fresh seafood, mi Quang and local noodle dishes.
BUDGET	Estimated day spend: AUD 85-120.

DAY 13 | DA NANG

Marble Mountains & final beach evening

TIME	PLAN
07:30	Breakfast.
08:30-11:00	Visit Marble Mountains early to avoid midday heat and heavier group traffic.
11:30-12:45	Lunch.
13:00-16:30	Spa, hotel pool or rest.
17:00-19:00	Final full beach session.
19:30-21:00	Vietnamese farewell dinner: mi Quang and/or seafood.
STAY	Stay: same Da Nang hotel.
FOOD / EXPERIENCE	Keep the afternoon free rather than adding Ba Na Hills; the trip should still feel relaxed on Day 13.
BUDGET	Estimated day spend: AUD 85-125.

DAY 14 | DA NANG

Easy departure

TIME	PLAN
09:00	Breakfast.
10:00-11:30	Final cafe or beach walk.
12:00	Check out.
Afternoon	Lunch, massage or coffee depending on flight time.
Later	Transfer to Da Nang International Airport with a comfortable buffer.
STAY	Do not add a long day trip on departure day.
FOOD / EXPERIENCE	Food target: revisit whichever Vietnamese dish became your favourite.
BUDGET	Estimated pre-airport spend: AUD 30-60, excluding flight.

Food Trail

Destination	What to prioritise	Good meal budget
Hanoi	Pho bo / pho ga, bun cha, banh cuon, banh mi, egg coffee	AUD 3-8 casual; AUD 10-20 sit-down
Ninh Binh	Home-style Vietnamese food, rice dishes, local goat if interested	AUD 4-12
Pu Luong	Sticky rice, grilled meats, mountain vegetables, homestay/resort meals	AUD 5-15
Hoi An	Banh mi, cao lau, white rose dumplings, chicken rice	AUD 3-12
Da Nang	Mi Quang, seafood, local noodle dishes	AUD 4-20 depending on seafood

Budget Snapshot

CATEGORY	PLANNING RANGE (AUD)	NOTES
Accommodation - 13 nights	650-900	Comfortable private rooms; lower per person if two travellers share.
Food & coffee	250-350	Mostly local meals with room for cafes and several nicer dinners.
Ground transport	100-160	Grab, vans and local transfers; private Pu Luong transfer can push this high.
Hanoi -> Da Nang flight	50-100+	Date, baggage and booking timing matter.
Trang An boating	~16	Allow extra for transfer to/from the pier.
Other attraction tickets	30-50	Planning allowance.
Cooking class	30-50	Small-group class.
Massage / leisure / extras	70-120	Optional.
TOTAL	1,200-1,750	Excludes international flights and shopping.

Crowd-Proofing the Trip

1. Go early, not faster. For Trang An, Hoi An Ancient Town and Marble Mountains, an early start matters more than packing in extra attractions. **2. Protect the afternoon.** Summer heat and crowds both peak during the middle of the day; use that time for the hotel, pool, spa or cafes. **3. Keep escape options.** If Hoi An feels too busy, switch to An Bang Beach. If Hanoi feels overwhelming, spend more time around West Lake. **4. Choose small-group experiences.** A small cooking class or private transfer fits this itinerary much better than large coach tours. **5. Do not chase every famous sight.** Ha Long Bay, Sapa, Ho Chi Minh City and Ba Na Hills are deliberately excluded to preserve the relaxed pace.

Final Booking Checklist

1	Book international flights once dates are fixed.
2	Reserve Hanoi, Tam Coc, Pu Luong, Hoi An and Da Nang accommodation with free cancellation where practical.
3	Book Hanoi-Da Nang flight and check baggage allowance.
4	Arrange Ninh Binh-Pu Luong and Pu Luong-Hanoi transfers in advance.
5	Book the Hoi An cooking class with a small-group option.

6	Keep at least one flexible day in Hoi An and avoid prepaying unnecessary tours.
7	Recheck weather and attraction hours shortly before departure.

Price note: All figures are planning estimates rather than guaranteed live prices. Exact costs vary by travel month, weekend/holiday demand, hotel room type, airline baggage and how early you book. Once exact dates are chosen, the itinerary should be repriced before payment.